Cuban American historian Alejandro de la Fuente took a comprehensive look at the Revolution's successes – and failures – with respect to racial inequality. In a number of key socioeconomic areas, Cuba presents a dramatic contrast with the United States and Brazil, two other countries with large populations of African descent. In life expectancy, educational achievement, and professional opportunity, the gap between the races shrank or disappeared in Cuba, while remaining seemingly insurmountable in the United States and Brazil. These achievements correlate with the priority the Revolution placed on improving and equalizing access to health care and education – and its overall success in these areas.

In other areas, the Revolution was less successful both in improving people's lives overall, and in narrowing the racial disparities it had inherited. De la Fuente noted two in particular: housing and criminality. With respect to housing, he noted that the improvement in the island's housing stock had remained a trouble area for the Revolution over its many decades. Not only was the housing supply chronically inadequate, there was also little change in the geographical and residential racial demographics of the island. "The government's failure to meet housing demands allowed for the survival and reproduction of traditional residential patterns which combined race with poverty and marginalization," he wrote.[12]

While the residential disparities might be explained as an inheritance of pre-revolutionary patterns, the second racial gap that de la Fuente uncovered was both more complex and more troubling. Just like in the United States and Brazil, blacks in Cuba were incarcerated at significantly higher rates than whites. De la Fuente notes that for the particularly racialized criminal category of "social dangerousness" – a vaguely defined category – 78 percent of those arrested were people of color (blacks and mulattoes) in a 1987 study. "Social dangerousness" charges included violations like drug and alcohol use and vagrancy. "Such a lax, broad definition of antisocial behavior created enough room for racialized notions of proper conduct to be enforced more freely than under the specific provisions of the penal code," de la Fuente concludes.[13]